

skylight. Sophie noticed that Alberto had put different objects out in place of some of those she had seen last time.

On the coffee table was a small antique casket containing an assorted collection of lenses for eyeglasses. Beside it lay an open book. It looked really old.

'What is that?' Sophie asked.

'It is a first edition of the book of Descartes's philosophical essays published in 1637 in which his famous *Discourse on Method* originally appeared, and one of my most treasured possessions.'

'And the casket?'

'It holds an exclusive collection of lenses—or optical glass. They were polished by the Dutch philosopher Spinoza sometime during the mid-1600s. They were extremely costly and are also among my most valued treasures.'

'I would probably understand better how valuable these things are if I knew who Spinoza and Descartes were.'

'Of course. But first let us try to familiarize ourselves with the period they lived in. Have a seat.'

They sat in the same places as before, Sophie in the big armchair and Alberto Knox on the sofa. Between them was the coffee table with the book and the casket. Alberto removed his wig and laid it on the writing desk.

'We are going to talk about the seventeenth century—or what we generally refer to as the Baroque period.'

'The Baroque period? What a strange name.'

'The word "baroque" comes from a word that was first used to describe a pearl of irregular shape. Irregularity was typical of Baroque art, which was much richer in highly contrastive forms than the plainer and more harmonious Renaissance art. The seventeenth century was on the whole characterized by tensions between irreconcilable contrasts. On the one hand there was the Renaissance's unremitting optimism—and on the other hand there were the many who sought the opposite extreme in a life of religious seclusion and self-denial. Both in art and in real life, we meet pompous and flamboyant forms of self-expression, while at the same time there arose a monastic movement, turning away from the world.'

'Both proud palaces and remote monasteries, in other words.'

'Yes, you could certainly say that. One of the Baroque period's favorite sayings was the Latin expression "*carpe diem*"—"seize the day." Another Latin expression that was widely quoted was "*memento mori*," which means "Remember that you must die." In